



Microsoft on Internet Explorer 8

Digit speaks to Rishi Srivastava, Consumer & Online Marketing Officer, Microsoft India

Some of the features offered by IE8 include: extensibility, private browsing, and better CSS compatibility. One might say that IE8 is merely catching up to its competition. What are your thoughts on this point of view?

IE8 has been designed to provide consumers with a faster, easier, safer and more reliable web experience.

Overall, IE8 RC1 has many innovative features such as:

- **Accelerators:** Certain common tasks such as search, browsing maps online, sharing content on social networking sites, email and translation involved several steps. These have now been cut short to just one click with accelerators. You can learn more about accelerators from www.ieaddons.com. Also, new accelerators are regularly being added to the Internet Explorer Gallery to further enhance browsing experiences.
- **Web slices:** As part of our daily browsing habits, we visit certain sites often. However, with web slices you can subscribe to portions of your favourite web sites, and with a single click in the Favorites bar, and view and interact with the latest updates you care about most. For example, you can see the latest headlines from a favourite news service, check the status or even bid on an auction, or view status updates from the social network — all without leaving the current page.
- **InPrivate Browsing:** By activating InPrivate Browsing, you can surf the web with greater confidence knowing that IE8 will not retain your browsing history, temporary internet files and cookies. This feature is useful when browsing at an internet café or using the kitchen PC to shop for gifts for friends that you don't want them to see. You can access InPrivate Browsing by either selecting a "new tab" or directly from the new Internet Explorer 8 Safety menu. IE8 was the first browser to introduce this capability. Additionally, Internet Explorer 8 includes a number of new features, such as:
- **Performance improvements:** Reduces the waiting time when starting the browser, or loading a page.
- **Enhanced "Find on this Page":** Enables you to find text on a web page more easily, in a way that does not obscure any of the page's content.
- **SmartScreen Filter:** Helps protect against phishing web sites, and sites known to distribute malware. It also helps detect and prevent "Clickjacking" which is a malicious technique of tricking web users into revealing confidential information or taking control of their computer.

- **Enhanced Address Bar:** Provides matches as the user types across History, Favorites, and RSS Feeds, searching against all parts of the URL string (and the page title) instead of just the beginning. Allows mistyped entries to be removed from the address bar.
- **Enhanced Instant Search Box:** Real-time search suggestions (including images) and inclusion of Web sites in the user's History make it easier to find content of interest.

What is the Microsoft gameplan vis-a-vis the runaway success of Mozilla Firefox? How will IE8 staunch the desktop browser's market share loss?

We respect the user's right to choose the browser that fits their needs. Internet Explorer 8 takes a big step forward in browser innovation focused on the way people use



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the web today. Faster, easier, safer and more reliable than ever before, Internet Explorer 8 RC1 is the best version of Internet Explorer we've released to date. For example, through Accelerators and Web Slices we are optimizing the browser experience by removing repetitive, time consuming actions.

In fact, Internet Explorer continues to be the most used browser platform on the Internet and Internet Explorer 7 is the most popular browser on the Windows operating systems as measured by usage.

With IE8, a Microsoft browser has passed the ACID 2 test. Why did it take this long for Microsoft to come to terms with standards, and more specifically to improve its CSS performance?

Since Beta 2, we have submitted about 2,500 additional CSS 2.1 tests. The final release of IE8 will fully support CSS 2.1 standards. We expect very few changes

between RC1 and the final release, but will include necessary adjustments as identified by the developer community.

What has been the most valuable lesson learned from IE7?

This is true for any release, but the most important thing we can do is listen to and respond to our customers. Because so many Internet Explorer users opt into providing feedback about how they use the product, we have a strong sense of what real people all around the world do on Internet Explorer. IE8 builds on the strong foundation of IE7 and reflects a deep understanding of what real people do in their browser everyday and makes those things faster and easier.

What improvements have you introduced in the developer toolset through IE8?

In IE8, the tools formerly available via the Internet Explorer Developer Toolbar are built directly into Internet Explorer 8 with expanded functionality (simply push F12 when using Internet Explorer 8). These tools enable developers to quickly debug HTML, CSS and JavaScript in a visual environment. Developers can quickly identify and resolve issues because of the deep insight the tool provides into the DOM.

Finally -- any chance of IE8 opening its source code? If not, why not?

Microsoft is committed to industry standards and IE8 addresses the three-core pieces of this support — broad compatibility, open documentation and open access.

Broad compatibility: To enhance interoperability of its high-volume products, Microsoft will determine which standards to implement, based on customer feedback, and work with other major implementers of those standards toward achieving robust, consistent and interoperable implementations across a broad range of widely deployed products.

Open documentation: To increase transparency and promote inter-operability, Microsoft will document how it supports those standards, including documentation of any extensions relevant to inter-operability.

Open access: As with its protocols and APIs, Microsoft will publish all information about its support for standards on its web site, including the specifics of standards extensions, without requiring developers to obtain a license, or to pay a royalty or other fee to access it. Microsoft will also make available a list of any of its patents that cover any of these extensions, and will make available patent licenses on RAND terms. ■

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